

However, with this change, almost every add-on will be completely broken and in need of major updating by the extension authors. Good luck with that.

"It is safe to say, that Firefox will not be Firefox any more as far as extensions go, but instead will become yet another Chrome-clone."

"To be clear: I was furious when the extension signing stuff was announced and then actually implemented, which effectively created yet another Walled Garden, but regarding this announcement, I am just sad. Right now, it feels like I just learned my dear old friend Firefox is going to die."

In April 2016, Mozilla announced that it is exploring the use of the Chrome rendering engine, in place of Mozilla's own Gecko rendering engine. Writing on the blog of what is called Project ToFino, senior vice president of the Firefox project, Mark Mayo wrote:

"Let's jump right in and say yes, the rumours are true, we're working on browser prototypes that look and feel almost nothing like the current Firefox... we're long overdue for some fresh approaches... the prototype we're feeling good about right now is built with Electron and React, not Gecko and XUL (our go-to technologies for building browsers)... Not having an awesome Firefox will kill Firefox. End of story."

Apparently, Mozilla feels a 'fresh approach' would have to involve the use of existing creations from Google

(Electron/Chromium) and Facebook (React). Electron is a framework for building desktop apps with Chromium, the open source base for the proprietary Google Chrome browser. Mozilla is using React to build Servo, which is expected to one day replace Gecko. Servo supports the Chromium Embedded Framework (CEF) that developers use to add a Chromium-based browser control to desktop applications and games. CEF development is led by Adobe and Valve.

Mozilla is hoping that by providing support for Electron and CEF, developers would be tempted to choose Servo in place of Chromium. In other words, Mozilla will be fighting for minnows. It will also be like closing the barn door after the horses have bolted. Would not Firefox be completely at the mercy of projects beyond Mozilla's leadership? Breaking changes in Chromium and CEF would affect Firefox. Instead of maintaining the entire code stack as it does now, Mozilla feels comfortable about ceding control of its flagship product to Google and other corporations. If Servo failed, then Chrome would be the winner anyway. By virtue of Google's distribution, it is Chrome, not Chromium, that dominates desktop browsing. If Servo does become better than Chromium, it will still have a tough time beating Google's dominance. Firefox beat IE for the first time only recently – that, too, after Microsoft replaced it with the Edge browser.

Earlier, in late 2015, Mozilla announced that it would put less resources on Thunderbird development and the larger open source community would have to take over. Mozilla's excuse was that people were using webmail and were less reliant on traditional desktop email clients. Around the same time, Mozilla announced that it would abandon the Firefox OS smartphone project. 

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